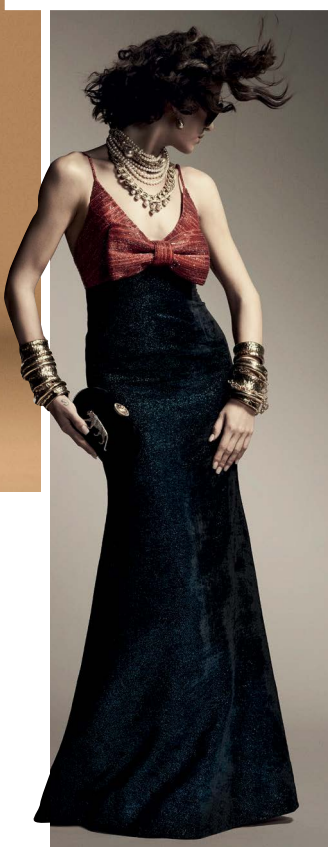
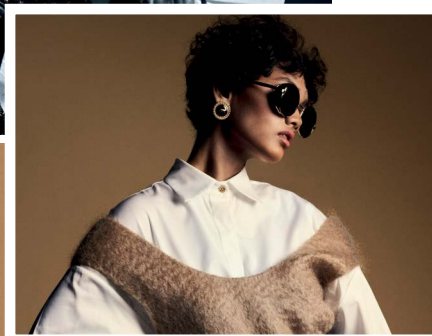




TRENDING

Some pieces from Sabyasachi's Autumn-Winter 2023 collection, which was launched directly on Instagram—a practice the brand has been following since 2016

they should, so that they can build tomorrow," says Mukherjee. "But what I want to do—while I'm still in my prime and I still have full control over my company—is to use the next 20 years to [plan for] tomorrow. I want to create my second-in-command; I want to create a succession plan. So that [brand] Sabyasachi does not go down with me; it deserves a much longer shelf life," says the designer who broke the rules by signing out of fashion weeks in India and

launching his collection directly on Instagram in 2016. It's a practice the brand continues with the latest Autumn-Winter 2023 collection having dropped on Instagram in mid-September. "Why bother with front row politics, when the world can be your front row," he says.

As he continues to grow, Mukherjee has not forgotten his middle-class roots. His father was the son of a refugee, raised by a single mother.

He was a chemical engineer who worked in a jute/wool mill that shut down and he lost his job. "My father gave maths tuitions, my mother taught art and I taught English as a teenager to make ends meet," he says, adding there was a time when he didn't want to go to school because he was traumatised with the privilege that his friends enjoyed. "I once saw my father crying while standing next to the kitchen sink. And I realised that's what money does to you. It brings you to your knees and strips you of your pride. I felt the same helplessness during Covid-19. I was responsible for all these people," says Mukherjee. However, after a conversation with his CFO, the designer was relieved to know that they could survive for three years and as a result, no one was let go.

Mukherjee says he had been in talks with billionaire Kumar Mangalam Birla, Chairman of the Aditya Birla Group, for a few years before Covid-19 and it was *his* decision to sell the majority stake to AB-FRL. He says he wanted to work with Birla for the way he has treated his children. "I think it takes a very wise parent to be able